

Word family: **break / breaks / broke / broken / breaking / breakage / breaker / unbreakable / breakthrough**

Base word: break

Past tense: broke

Past participle: broken

** -ing form:** breaking

Related forms:

* **breakage** (n.) — 破損；破裂；損壞量

* **breaker** (n.) — 破壞者；斷路器；碎浪

* **unbreakable** (adj.) — 不易打破的；牢不可破的

* **breakthrough** (n.) — 突破；重大進展

* **broken** (adj.) — 破損的；故障的；中斷的；不完整的

Useful extensions:

* **break something**

* **break a rule / law**

* **break a promise**

* **break a record**

* **break the news**

* **break the silence**

* **break someone's heart**

* **break down**

* **break up**

* **break out**

* **break in**

* **break into**

* **break off**

* **break through**

* **take a break**

* **coffee/lunch break**

* **school break**

* **break in the weather**

* **break in communication**

* **break even**

* **break free**

* **break with tradition**

Part of speech: mainly **verb** and **noun**

Meaning in this passage

> I still remember one family gathering when a younger child accidentally ****broke**** a cardboard bridge he had spent a long time making.

Here, ****broke**** means:

****damaged something so that it separated, cracked, collapsed, or no longer stayed intact — 弄壞；弄破；弄斷****

The cardboard bridge was physically damaged.

****中文翻譯：****

我仍然記得有一次家庭聚會，一個年紀較小的孩子不小心****弄壞了**** Leo 花了很長時間製作的紙板橋。

So here:

****break something = 使某物受損、破裂、斷裂或失去原本完整狀態****

1. ****break something (弄破 / 弄斷 / 弄壞) — 打破；弄壞；弄斷****

This is the core meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> A younger child accidentally ****broke a cardboard bridge****.

一個年紀較小的孩子不小心****弄壞了一座紙板橋****。

Practice 2

> Be careful not to ****break the glass****.

小心不要****打破玻璃杯****。

Practice 3

> He ****broke the chair**** by standing on it.

他站在椅子上，把椅子****弄壞了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break something = 使某物破裂、斷裂、損壞或失去完整狀態****

2. **something breaks** (某物破裂 / 壞掉) — 破裂；斷裂；壞掉

Intransitive use.

Practice 1

> The branch **broke** under his weight.

樹枝在他的重量下**斷了**。

Practice 2

> My phone screen **broke** when I dropped it.

我把手機掉在地上後，螢幕**破了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break = 某物本身破裂、斷裂或失去正常完整狀態

3. **break a bone** — 骨折

Practice 1

> She **broke her arm** in the accident.

她在意外中**摔斷了手臂 / 手臂骨折**。

Practice 2

> He fell off his bike but luckily didn't **break any bones**.

他從單車上摔下來，但幸好沒有**骨折**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a bone = 使骨頭斷裂，即骨折

4. **break a machine/device** (弄壞；使故障) — 弄壞；使不能正常運作

Practice 1

> I think I've **broken** the printer.

我想我把打印機**弄壞了**。

Practice 2

> Don't press that button—you might **break** the machine.

不要按那個按鈕，你可能會把機器**弄壞**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a machine/device = 使設備損壞至無法正常運作

5. **broken** (物件) — 破損的；壞掉的

Practice 1

> The toy is **broken**.

那件玩具**壞了**。

Practice 2

> He replaced the **broken** window.

他更換了那扇**破掉的窗**。

MCQ-ready definition:

broken = 已經破裂、損壞或不能正常使用的

6. **break a rule/law** — 違反規則 / 法律

A major abstract extension.

Practice 1

> Students who **break the rules** may be punished.

違反規則的學生可能會受罰。

Practice 2

> He was arrested for **breaking the law**.

他因**違法**而被捕。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a rule/law = 不遵守規則、制度或法律

7. **break a promise — 違背承諾；失信**

Practice 1

> She never **breaks a promise**.

她從不**違背承諾**。

Practice 2

> He felt guilty because he had **broken his promise**.

他因為**沒有守承諾**而感到內疚。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a promise = 沒有履行自己曾經作出的承諾

8. **break an agreement/contract — 違反協議 / 合約**

Practice 1

> The company was accused of **breaking the agreement**.

該公司被指控**違反協議**。

Practice 2

> Either side can be penalized for **breaking the contract**.

任何一方**違反合約**都可能受到處罰。

MCQ-ready definition:

break an agreement/contract = 不遵守協議或合約所訂明的條款

9. **break a record** — 打破紀錄

Practice 1

> She **broke the world record**.

她**打破了世界紀錄**。

Practice 2

> The film **broke several box-office records**.

這部電影**打破了多項票房紀錄**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a record = 超過之前最佳或最高的紀錄

10. **break the silence** — 打破沉默

Practice 1

> He finally **broke the silence**.

他終於**打破了沉默**。

Practice 2

> A sudden laugh **broke the silence** in the room.

突然一陣笑聲**打破了房間裏的寂靜**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break the silence = 使原本安靜、無人說話的狀態終止

11. **break the news** — 告訴某人重大 / 不好的消息

A fixed expression.

Practice 1

> Who is going to **break the news** to her?

誰來**把這個消息告訴她**？

Practice 2

> He gently **broke the news** that the trip had been cancelled.

他委婉地**告訴大家旅行取消了的消息**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break the news = 把重要、突然或令人難受的消息告訴某人

12. **break someone's heart** — 令某人傷心欲絕

Practice 1

> The decision **broke her heart**.

這個決定令她**非常心碎 / 傷心欲絕**。

Practice 2

> It **broke his heart** to leave his family behind.

要離開家人令他**非常難過**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break someone's heart = 令某人感到極度悲傷或痛苦

13. **break someone's spirit** — 摧毀某人的意志

Practice 1

> Years of hardship did not **break her spirit**.

多年的艱苦並沒有**摧毀她的意志**。

Practice 2

> The constant criticism almost **broke his spirit**.

持續的批評幾乎**擊垮了他的意志**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break someone's spirit = 使某人失去勇氣、希望或心理上的堅強****

14. ****break a habit — 戒掉 / 改掉習慣****

Practice 1

> It's difficult to ****break a bad habit****.

要****戒掉壞習慣****並不容易。

Practice 2

> He is trying to ****break the habit of checking his phone constantly****.

他正嘗試****改掉不停查看手機的習慣****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break a habit = 停止一個已形成並反覆出現的習慣****

15. ****break a pattern/cycle — 打破模式 / 循環****

Practice 1

> We need to ****break the cycle of poverty****.

我們需要****打破貧窮循環****。

Practice 2

> She changed her routine to ****break the pattern****.

她改變日常習慣來****打破原有模式****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break a pattern/cycle = 使一個持續重複的模式或循環停止****

16. ****break contact / communication — 中斷聯絡 / 溝通****

Practice 1

> They **“broke contact”** after the argument.

爭吵後，他們**“中斷了聯絡”**。

Practice 2

> The storm **“broke communication”** with the island.

暴風雨**“中斷了與該島的通訊”**。

“MCQ-ready definition:”

“break contact/communication = 使持續的聯絡或溝通停止”

17. **“break someone's concentration — 打斷專注”**

Practice 1

> The noise **“broke my concentration”**.

噪音**“打斷了我的專注”**。

Practice 2

> Try not to **“break her concentration”** while she's working.

她工作時盡量不要**“打斷她的思路”**。

“MCQ-ready definition:”

“break someone's concentration = 令某人停止原本持續的專注狀態”

18. **“break the fall — 減輕跌落的衝擊”**

Practice 1

> The branches **“broke his fall”**.

樹枝**“減輕了他墜落時的衝擊”**。

Practice 2

> She put out her hands to **break her fall**.

她伸出雙手來**減輕**跌倒時的衝力。

MCQ-ready definition:

break a fall = 減弱跌落或跌倒時的衝擊力

19. **break someone's fall** — 承接 / 減輕某人跌落

Practice 1

> The soft ground helped **break her fall**.

柔軟的地面幫助**減輕**了她跌倒時的衝擊。

Practice 2

> He landed on some bushes, which **broke his fall**.

他跌在一些灌木上，灌木**減輕**了下墜的衝擊。

MCQ-ready definition:

break someone's fall = 使某人跌落時的衝擊減少

20. **break down (機器)** — 故障；壞掉

Highly common phrasal extension.

Practice 1

> Our car **broke down** on the way home.

我們的車回家途中**壞了**。

Practice 2

> The lift **broke down** again.

升降機又**故障了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****break down = 機器或車輛停止正常運作****

21. ****break down (人) — 情緒崩潰；大哭****

Practice 1

> She ****broke down**** when she heard the news.

她聽到消息後****情緒崩潰了****。

Practice 2

> He ****broke down in tears****.

他****忍不住哭了起來****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break down = 因強烈情緒而失去控制，通常哭泣或無法繼續正常應對****

22. ****break down (關係 / 談判 / 系統) — 破裂；失敗****

Practice 1

> Negotiations ****broke down****.

談判****破裂了****。

Practice 2

> Communication between the two teams ****broke down****.

兩個團隊之間的溝通****失效 / 中斷了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break down = 原本運作中的關係、談判或系統停止有效運作****

23. ****break something down — 分解；拆分****

Practice 1

> The teacher **broke** the problem down into smaller steps.

老師把問題**拆分成幾個較小步驟**。

Practice 2

> The body **breaks** food down during digestion.

身體在消化過程中會把食物**分解**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break something down = 把整體分成較小部分，使其更容易處理、理解或消化

24. **break up** (關係) — 分手；關係結束

Practice 1

> They **broke up** last year.

他們去年**分手了**。

Practice 2

> She decided to **break up** with him.

她決定**跟他分手**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break up = 戀愛關係或婚姻關係結束

25. **break up** (群體) — 解散；散開

Practice 1

> The police **broke up** the crowd.

警方**驅散了人群**。

Practice 2

> The meeting **broke up** at six.

會議在六點**散會**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break up = 一個群體停止聚集，或被迫分散****

26. ****break something up — 打碎；分割****

Practice 1

> ****Break up**** the chocolate into small pieces.

把朱古力**掰成小塊**。

Practice 2

> The land was ****broken up into smaller plots****.

土地被**分割成較小地塊**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break something up = 把一個整體分成若干較小部分****

27. ****break out (戰爭 / 火災 / 疾病突然發生) — 爆發****

Practice 1

> A fire ****broke out**** during the night.

晚上突然**發生火災**。

Practice 2

> Fighting ****broke out**** near the border.

邊境附近**爆發了戰鬥**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break out = 戰爭、火災、疾病、暴力等突然開始****

28. ****break out of somewhere — 逃出****

Practice 1

> Two prisoners **broke out of jail**.

兩名囚犯**越獄逃走**。

Practice 2

> The animal **broke out of its cage**.

那隻動物**逃出了籠子**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break out of somewhere = 強行逃離被困或被關閉的地方

29. **break in (闖入) — 強行進入**

Practice 1

> Someone tried to **break in** last night.

昨晚有人試圖**闖入**。

Practice 2

> Thieves **broke in** through a window.

小偷從窗戶**闖了進去**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break in = 未經許可強行進入建築物

30. **break into somewhere — 闖入某地**

Practice 1

> Someone **broke into the office**.

有人**闖入了辦公室**。

Practice 2

> Burglars ****broke into the house**** while the owners were away.

屋主不在時，爆竊者****闖入了房子****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break into somewhere = 強行、非法進入某個地方****

31. ****break into laughter/tears — 突然大笑 / 哭起來****

A different extension of ****break into****.

Practice 1

> Everyone ****broke into laughter****.

大家突然****大笑起來****。

Practice 2

> She ****broke into tears**** after reading the letter.

她讀完那封信後突然****哭了起來****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break into laughter/tears = 突然開始大笑或哭泣****

32. ****break off — 突然停止；中斷****

Practice 1

> He ****broke off**** in the middle of his sentence.

他說到一半突然****停了下來****。

Practice 2

> The two countries ****broke off negotiations****.

兩國****中斷了談判****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break off = 突然停止正在進行的談話、關係或活動****

33. ****break through — 突破；衝破****

Practice 1

> The sun ****broke through the clouds****.

陽光****穿透了雲層****。

Practice 2

> The rescue team finally ****broke through the barrier****.

救援隊終於****突破了障礙****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break through = 穿過或突破阻擋前進的東西****

34. ****breakthrough (n.) — 突破；重大進展****

Practice 1

> Scientists made an important ****breakthrough****.

科學家取得了一項重要****突破****。

Practice 2

> The treatment could represent a major medical ****breakthrough****.

這項治療可能代表一項重大的醫學****突破****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****breakthrough = 在研究、問題或發展中取得的重要新進展****

35. ****break free — 掙脫；擺脫束縛****

Practice 1

> The dog **broke free** from the rope.

那隻狗從繩子中**掙脫了**。

Practice 2

> She wanted to **break free** from old expectations.

她想**擺脫舊有期望的束縛**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break free = 成功脫離身體上或抽象上的限制、控制或束縛

36. **break with tradition** — 打破傳統；不再遵循傳統

Practice 1

> The designer **broke with tradition** and used a completely new style.

設計師**打破傳統**，採用了全新的風格。

Practice 2

> The company **broke with past practice**.

公司**不再沿用過去的做法**。

MCQ-ready definition:

break with something = 停止遵從某種傳統、習慣或既有做法

37. **take a break** — 休息一下

As a noun, **break** can mean a pause.

Practice 1

> Let's **take a break**.

我們**休息一下**吧。

Practice 2

> I need a short **break** after working for three hours.

工作了三小時後，我需要短暫**休息**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a break = 工作、活動或學習中的短暫停止時間

38. **coffee/lunch break — 咖啡休息 / 午膳休息**

Practice 1

> We usually have a **coffee break** at eleven.

我們通常十一點有一次**小休**。

Practice 2

> I'll call you during my **lunch break**.

我會在**午膳休息時間**打電話給你。

MCQ-ready definition:

break = 工作或學習期間安排的短暫休息時間

39. **school break / holiday break — 學校假期；休假期**

Practice 1

> The children are home for the summer **break**.

孩子們正在放暑假。

Practice 2

> We travelled during the Christmas **break**.

我們在聖誕**假期**期間旅行。

MCQ-ready definition:

break = 一段暫停上課、工作或日常安排的假期

40. **a break in something — 中斷；間隙**

Practice 1

> There was a short **break in the rain**.

雨勢有一小段**停頓**。

Practice 2

> We finally had a **break in the traffic**.

車流終於出現一個**空隙**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a break in something = 一個持續狀態中出現的短暫中斷或空隙

41. **break in communication/contact — 溝通 / 聯絡中斷**

Practice 1

> There was a **break in communication** between the departments.

部門之間出現了**溝通中斷**。

Practice 2

> A technical problem caused a **break in contact**.

技術問題造成**聯絡中斷**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a break in X = 某種連續的活動、聯絡或狀態出現中斷

42. **break even — 收支平衡；不賺不蝕**

A common business expression.

Practice 1

> The company hopes to **break even** this year.

公司希望今年能夠**收支平衡**。

Practice 2

> We sold enough tickets to **break even**.

我們賣出了足夠門票，剛好**不賺不蝕**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****break even = 收入剛好等於成本，沒有盈利也沒有虧損****

43. ****give someone a break — 放某人一馬；讓某人輕鬆一點****

Practice 1

> Come on, ****give him a break****. He's new here.

好了，****別對他那麼苛刻****，他才剛來。

Practice 2

> Could you ****give me a break****? I've been working all day.

你可不可以****讓我休息一下 / 別再為難我****？我已經工作了一整天。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****give someone a break = 對某人少一點要求、批評或壓力；有時也指讓某人得到休息****

44. ****get a break — 得到機會 / 好運****

Practice 1

> She finally ****got her big break**** in the film industry.

她終於在電影業獲得了****重大機會****。

Practice 2

> He just needs one ****break**** to show what he can do.

他只需要一個****機會****來證明自己的能力。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a break = 能帶來成功或改善處境的重要機會或好運****

45. ****big break — 重大機會；成名契機****

Practice 1

> The role became her ****big break****.

那個角色成為她的****成名契機****。

Practice 2

> He got his ****big break**** when a producer heard him sing.

一名製作人聽到他唱歌後，他便獲得了****重大發展機會****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****big break = 能令事業或人生出現重大進展的重要機會****

Important distinction 1: ****break vs damage****

****break****

often suggests something becomes cracked, separated, non-functional, or loses integrity.

> I ****broke the chair****.

我把椅子弄壞了。

****damage****

is broader and may involve partial harm without complete breakage.

> The chair was ****damaged****.

椅子受損了。

So something can be ****damaged but not broken****.

Important distinction 2: **break** vs **crack**

crack

means form a narrow split or line.

> The glass **cracked**.

玻璃裂了。

break

broader; it may crack, split, snap, shatter, collapse, or stop functioning.

> The glass **broke**.

玻璃破了。

Important distinction 3: **break** vs **smash**

break

neutral and broad.

smash

stronger; often suggests violent impact and severe breakage.

> He **broke** the glass.

他打破了玻璃。

> He **smashed** the glass.

他把玻璃**砸碎了**。

Important distinction 4: **break** vs **tear**

break

commonly for hard or structural objects.

tear

for paper, cloth, skin, etc.

> **break** a stick

> 折斷木棍

> **tear** paper

> 撕紙

Important distinction 5: **break a rule vs break a promise**

These share the abstract idea of **violating something that should be maintained**, but:

* **break a rule** = 不遵守規則

* **break a promise** = 不履行承諾

They are separate collocational branches under the same abstract semantic extension.

Important distinction 6: **break vs violate**

break a law/rule

ordinary English

violate a law/rule

more formal

> He **broke the law**.

> He **violated the law**.

Both can mean **違法**, but **violate** is more formal/legal.

Important distinction 7: **break down vs break**

break

broad:

> The machine ****broke****.

機器壞了。

****break down****

especially natural for machines/vehicles failing to function:

> The car ****broke down****.

車拋錨了。

Important distinction 8: ****broken vs broke****

Very important.

****broke****

past tense verb:

> I ****broke**** the cup.

我打破了杯子。

****broken****

past participle/adjective:

> I have ****broken**** the cup.

我已經打破了杯子。

> The cup is ****broken****.

杯子破了。

Also note that ****broke**** can separately be an informal adjective meaning ****沒有錢****, but that is a different lexical use:

> I'm ****broke****.

我沒錢了 / 身無分文。

46. **broke (informal adjective) — 沒錢的 ; 身無分文的**

This is a genuine lexicalized adjective, distinct from past-tense **broke**.

Practice 1

> I can't go out tonight—I'm **broke**.

我今晚不能出去，我**沒錢了**。

Practice 2

> He was completely **broke** after paying the bills.

付完帳單後，他**幾乎身無分文**。

MCQ-ready definition:

broke = 沒有錢或幾乎沒有錢的

Register: informal.

Important distinction 9: **break up vs break down**

break up

often:

- * relationship ends
- * group disperses
- * whole divided into parts

break down

often:

- * machine fails
- * person collapses emotionally
- * system/negotiation fails
- * something is divided analytically

These should not be mixed.

Important distinction 10: **break out** vs **break in**

break out

get **out** of confinement / suddenly begin

> break out of prison

> 越獄

> war breaks out

> 戰爭爆發

break in

get **into** a building illegally

> thieves broke in

> 小偷闖入

The directional image helps learners remember them.

Important distinction 11: **take a break** vs **break something**

These are two completely different POS/sense branches:

Verb

> **break** the bridge

> 弄壞橋

Noun

> take a **break**

> 休息一下

This is genuine polysemy, not merely a grammar change.

Important distinction 12: **break** vs **pause**

break

often a period when activity stops, sometimes scheduled.

> lunch **break**

午膳休息

pause

usually a shorter temporary stop within an ongoing activity.

> a brief **pause** in the conversation

談話中的短暫停頓

Important distinction 13: **break someone's heart vs break someone's spirit**

break someone's heart

= cause deep sadness

break someone's spirit

= destroy courage, hope, or determination

Both are figurative, but the emotional target differs.

Important distinction 14: **breakthrough vs break through**

break through — verb phrase

> Scientists **broke through** the barrier.

科學家突破了障礙。

breakthrough — noun

> a scientific **breakthrough**

科學突破

Spelling and grammar differ.

Family-extension note

Break is one of the strongest polysemy verbs in English. Its semantic branches are broad but still traceable to a core idea:

something continuous, intact, functioning, or established stops being whole or uninterrupted

From that core we get:

1. **physical damage**

- * break a bridge
- * break a glass
- * break a bone

2. **rules and obligations**

- * break a law
- * break a promise
- * break a contract

3. **ending continuity**

- * break the silence
- * break contact
- * break a habit
- * break a cycle

4. **figurative emotional damage**

- * break someone's heart
- * break someone's spirit

5. **phrasal extensions**

- * break down
- * break up
- * break out
- * break in
- * break through

6. **noun meanings**

- * take a break
- * a break in the weather
- * get a big break

This is exactly the kind of family where broad scanning is essential, but conservative grouping still matters: not every collocation should become a totally separate “meaning” if it preserves the same underlying concept.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
-----	-----	-----	
break something	弄破；弄壞；弄斷	physically damage	
something breaks	破裂；壞掉	lose integrity	
break a bone	骨折	bone fractures	
broken	破損的；壞掉的	damaged state	
break a rule/law	違反規則 / 法律	violate	
break a promise	違背承諾	fail obligation	
break a contract	違反合約	violate agreement	
break a record	打破紀錄	exceed previous best	
break the silence	打破沉默	end silence	
break the news	告知重大消息	deliver news	
break someone's heart	令某人心碎	cause deep sadness	
break someone's spirit	擊垮意志	destroy morale	
break a habit	戒掉習慣	stop repeated behavior	
break a cycle	打破循環	stop repeated pattern	
break contact	中斷聯絡	end continuity	
break concentration	打斷專注	interrupt focus	
break a fall	減輕跌落衝擊	reduce impact	
break down (machine)	故障	stop functioning	
break down (person)	情緒崩潰	lose emotional control	
break down (talks/system)	破裂；失效	cease functioning	
break something down	分解；拆分	divide into parts	
break up (relationship)	分手	end relationship	
break up (group)	散開；解散	disperse	
break out	爆發	suddenly begin	
break out of	逃出	escape	
break in	闖入	enter illegally	
break into laughter	突然大笑	suddenly begin	
break off	中斷；突然停止	terminate	
break through	突破	pass barrier	
breakthrough	突破；重大進展	major advance	

break free	掙脫；擺脫	escape restraint	
break with tradition	打破傳統	reject established practice	
take a break	休息一下	temporary pause	
lunch break	午膳休息	scheduled pause	
school break	學校假期	period off	
a break in X	中斷；間隙	temporary interruption	
break even	收支平衡	no profit/loss	
give someone a break	放某人一馬	reduce pressure	
big break	重大機會	career opportunity	
broke (adj.)	沒錢的	informal financial state	

For your original sentence

> I still remember one family gathering when a younger child accidentally **break** a cardboard bridge he had spent a long time making.

Here:

break = 弄壞；使失去完整結構

The cardboard bridge was physically intact before, and the younger child accidentally caused it to become damaged.

So the semantic path is simply:

whole/intact object
→ **physical damage**
→ **broken object**

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 一個年紀較小的孩子不小心**弄壞了** Leo 花了很長時間製作的紙板橋。

For this passage, this is the **literal physical-damage sense** of **break**.